

5, The Clumsy Lies of the Chinese Rulers

Alas! How could anyone else fathom the sheer depth of my despair when I realized all this!

The Chinese commoners exhibit a myriad of vices, but who exactly turned them into this? For how many ages has the court imprisoned the populace like criminals as a robber would, plundered their wealth and grain like a thief, and deluded their minds like a fraudster?

In the past, when there was an emperor, whatever the emperor proclaimed was absolute truth; everyone existed merely to serve the interests of the "sovereign-father" (君父). The most ludicrous tragedy is that, even today, this remains completely unchanged.

Today, Chinese people still mechanically recite the dogma that "*successive dynasties perished due to land annexation*" (土地兼并). They treat **aristocratic great clans** (门阀) and meritorious nobles (勋贵) as the enemies of the realm, terrified that someone might challenge the supreme authority of the sovereign-father. How utterly farcical!

Setting aside the fact that, judging by China's final two dynasties, land annexation never even formed a significant scale. At the grassroots level, land property rights were shattered and fragmented due to the **partible inheritance** (析产) and systemic suppression enforced by the **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家). The number and scale of large landlords bore absolutely no comparison to the whole of Europe, let alone countries like Britain or Poland.

Viewing the **aristocratic great clans** and nobles as social parasites is simply turning black into white (颠倒黑白). Yes, the nobles and aristocratic great clans in Chinese history indeed achieved little, but the question remains: *who made them this way?*

If these landlords or large landlords—who possessed a certain social status—wished to participate more in social governance and shoulder the military obligations of the state, would the emperor have ever permitted it?

It was blatantly the bureaucratic government, headed by the emperor, that feared and guarded against a united **feudal lord class** (封建领主阶级). Therefore, the state exhausted every means to weaken them: stripping them of the right to participate in social governance and shoulder military duties, obstructing them by all means from enhancing their strength through technological improvements, and remaining highly vigilant lest they acquire lofty social prestige through any channel. Ultimately, this forced the landed aristocrats into a state of idle, hedonistic consumption, rendering them entirely useless to the realm.

Admittedly, the fact that China's landlord class failed to seize political power is a historical tragedy, stemming first and foremost from their own incompetence. Yet, no person with conscience can ignore the fact that in the suppression of the landlord class, the **bureaucratic state** headed by the emperor was the true perpetrator of the crime.

That such an obvious fact is twisted into an explanation that the landed aristocrats were inherently incompetent parasites contributing nothing to social production—is this not as absurd as an abuser breaking a victim's legs and then mocking them for being disabled?

What leaves one truly dumbfounded is that such a "person," beaten into disability, is actually forced to bear the guilt for the subversion of the entire empire!

A simplest fact is this: in the typical **feudal societies** of Europe and Japan, the devastating, realm-sweeping peasant wars characteristic of the late dynasties following China's bureaucratic restoration simply did not exist. The contradictions between peasants and **feudal lords** (封建领主) were often resolved within a contained scope. Even in large-scale uprisings, both sides exercised far more restraint than those in Chinese history.

We must point out without any hesitation that the root cause of the total social collapse occurring at the final stage of every cycle of the **Dynastic cycle** (王朝周期律) lies in this: the destruction of social production by a hyper-inflated bureaucratic system, utterly incapable of self-correction, reached such an extreme that, on a nationwide scale, even maintaining the original scale of economic production became impossible.

Such a degree of annihilation is fundamentally impossible under a **feudal system** (封建体制). The **feudal lords** themselves were the possessors of the **means of production** (生产资料), the organizers of production, and its direct beneficiaries. Unless they were madmen, they would never drive economic production to such a level of destruction without pulling back from the precipice (悬崖勒马).

Even if one or two madmen inevitably appeared within a certain population base, a **feudal society** itself was never a centralized, monistic society like a **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家). Lords of all sizes had their own **direct demesnes** (直辖领地) to manage. Even if one or two lords were truly that insane, how could the vast majority of lords nationwide possibly go mad simultaneously?

Yet, our country's current historical propaganda is self-contradictory to this extent: on the one hand, it treats the **feudal landlord class**—persecuted and mutilated by the **bureaucratic state**—as useless degenerates who only knew how to indulge themselves; on the other hand, it accuses these very "degenerates" of destroying the entire country!

Is this laughable narrative even the slightest bit different from the absurd tale of a robber who beats a person into disability, only to turn around and accuse this disabled person of committing an unforgivable criminal offense—an offense of which the robber himself was the true culprit?

The tragic reality is that the vast majority of Chinese commoners believe this narrative. To them, the court and the emperor are forever wise and infallible; *"their original intentions are always good,"* and the evil ones are always the landlords and local officials.

This narrative, of course, does not solely target the landlord class as the ruling class. As for the ruled class—who constituted the vast majority of the population—in this narrative, they were fundamentally treated as untouchables with a status no different from livestock.

For instance, when I was in high school, the standard history textbooks would explain why China did not spontaneously generate an Industrial Revolution or enter a capitalist society. Within that explanation, the infamous reply from the Qianlong Emperor to Macartney was invariably cited (*"The Celestial Empire possesses all things in prolific abundance..."*).

Students were then told that China's own **productive forces** (生产力) were already overproducing, enjoying a trade surplus for consecutive years prior to the massive rise of the opium trade. Therefore, China allegedly lacked both the motivation to improve production and the willingness to proactively undertake overseas expansion.

This explanation is so cunning that it almost always succeeds in deceiving high school students, who, due to academic pressure and shallow life experience, are incapable of profound reflection. They cannot yet comprehend that production and consumption are mutually correlated counterparts; **what is termed "overproduction" is, from another perspective, simply "underconsumption."**

In fact, the history following the Opium War completely proved this point. The reason the British Parliament narrowly approved launching a war against China was ultimately because they presumed that by forcing China to open its doors, they would reap colossal profits from this "massive" Chinese market.

However, the events following the Opium War slapped the British hard in the face: the Chinese were so utterly impoverished that they possessed absolutely zero capacity to consume British products. The entire market of 400 million people in the Qing Dynasty astonishingly could not match that of a single Mexico!

Thus, this issue was twisted from *"Why were the Chinese commoners plunged into such horrific, inhumane extreme poverty?"* into *"How magnificent our country is, capable of producing so much social wealth without even needing machines!"*

The bureaucratic system not only washed its hands of its monstrous crimes, but even more outrageously, it provided a stimulant of nationalism (民族主义的兴奋剂) for the pitiable, unthinking commoners. I would very much like to ask: Who exactly forced the Chinese commoners to struggle day and night on the brink of starvation, to the point that their contribution to consumption was virtually zero?

Actually, if one lives in China for a period of time, they will realize with crystal clarity that, whether in the past or present, the Chinese rulers essentially view their people as livestock. Deep down, they believe that as long as the people can stay alive, they have no need for surplus wealth and are fundamentally unworthy of engaging in consumption.

Among China's "Troika" (三驾马车 / the three major drivers of economic growth) in the past, the only horse that was genuinely galloping was foreign trade and exports. As for investment and consumption—what did they even amount to in the eyes of the rulers?

It wasn't until recent years that this situation was severely exacerbated by a sharp demographic downturn, as the cost advantage of "Made in China" is being neutralized by countries in Asia, Africa, and Latin America that similarly possess abundant labor forces.

The United States and China have openly engaged in a trade war, while our country's capacity for technological innovation is extremely impoverished, possessing virtually no competitiveness in various industries, especially high-value-added ones. Coupled with the growing estrangement between China and the West, particularly the US, and the fact that our country's so-called "market economy system" is fundamentally a joke (*actually, almost everyone in China knows this, they just don't say it aloud*), developed countries are naturally far more willing to choose other developing countries with lower costs and safer investment guarantees when relocating their industries.

The galloping horse of foreign exports has finally lost its momentum. The subsequent three years of ludicrous pandemic controls dealt another crushing blow to this already gasping old horse.

Only at this moment did the Chinese rulers suddenly remember "consumption" (*they certainly wouldn't count on investment, because they know full well what kind of investment environment*

China is). Officials big and small are desperate to squeeze every last coin out of the commoners. But the commoners have long since been drained of money; countless people have emptied their "coffin savings" (棺材本) just to pay off their mortgages.

Later, a serendipitous incident made me realize that the government has, in fact, been systematically and purposefully guiding and restricting people's thoughts all along.

Young people in China are not unfamiliar with web novels. Even if you hardly read them, as long as you are continually exposed to the internet, you will always hear about one or two breakout works. I myself do not read web novels much, only occasionally scrolling through them when I have nothing to do.

At the end of 2023, I stumbled upon an alternative history novel written by a domestic author. The plot roughly involved overseas Chinese establishing an independent nation during the Age of Discovery.

After reading a few dozen chapters, I suddenly discovered a statement left by the author at the end of a particular chapter. He explained that his original intended plot was for the Chinese to establish a bourgeois democratic republic overseas. However, the platform's staff told him that to pass the censorship review, **the protagonist of such a novel MUST claim the throne and refer to himself as emperor (称孤道寡)**. Therefore, he had no choice but to change the plot to declaring himself emperor overseas. But he added that he would still stick to his ideals; even if he wrote about an emperor, it would absolutely be a constitutional monarchy.

This incident inflicted a colossal shock upon me. For the first time, I felt so tangibly that the land I live in is a gigantic cage (庞大的囚笼). **The Chinese rulers are terrified that the commoners might forget the majesty of the emperor; they fret day and night that one day, the people might discover they actually do not have to kneel when encountering an official.**

5, 中国统治者的拙劣谎言

唉！其他人又怎么会理解当我意识到这些的时候有多失望！中国的老百姓有各种各样的恶习，是谁把他们变成这样的？朝廷像强盗一样将百姓如犯人般囚禁，像窃贼一样偷走百姓的钱粮，像诈骗犯一样迷惑百姓的心智，尔来已经多少岁月？过去有皇帝的时候，皇帝说什么都是对的，人人要为君父的利益服务，最可笑之事莫过于今天竟仍然如此。今天中国人嘴里还念叨着“历朝历代亡于土地兼并”，把门阀、勋贵视为天下之敌，唯恐有人能挑战君父的九五至尊，这是何其可笑！且不说土地兼并从中国最后两个朝代来看根本就没有形成过规模，社会基层的土地产权因为官僚国家的析产和打击支离破碎，大地主的地主数量和规模跟整个欧洲都没有可比性，更不要说像英国或者波兰这样的国家了。把门阀勋贵视为社会的寄生虫更是干脆颠倒黑白，是的，中国历史上的勋贵和门阀的确少有作为，但还是那句话，谁让他们变成这样的？这些有一定社会地位的地主或者大地主如果想要更多参与社会治理，承担国家的军事义务，请问皇帝会同意吗？明明是以皇帝为首的官僚政府恐惧和防范一个联合起来的封建领主阶级，因此想尽办法对他们进行削弱，剥夺他们参与社会治理和承担军事义务的权力，千方百计阻挠他们通过技术改良提高自身实力，警惕他们无论通过何种途径获得崇高的社会威望，最终迫使土地贵族们只能进行无所事事的享受型消费而无益于天下。诚然，中国的地主阶级没有夺取政权是历史的遗憾，这首先是他们自己的无能，但是任何有良知的人都不会忽视在对地主阶级的打压中，以皇帝为首的官僚国家是罪行的发出者。如此显而易见的事却被解释为土地贵族自己无能，是无益于社会生产的寄生虫，这不就相当于施暴者打断了受害者的腿，反而嘲笑后者是残疾人一样荒诞吗？最令人瞠目结舌的是，就是这样一个被打成残疾的“人”，居然还要承担天下倾覆的罪责。

一个最简单的事实是，在欧洲和日本的典型封建社会根本就不存在像中国官僚复辟之后王朝晚期席卷天下的极具破坏性的农民战争，农民与封建领主之间的矛盾往往会被控制在一定范围内解决，即使是规模较大的起义双方也远比中国历史上的起义要克制。我们应该毫不客气地指出，所谓王朝周期律每个循环最后阶段发生的社会的总崩溃，其根本原因在于高度膨胀和完全无法自我纠错的官僚体制对社会生产的破坏达到了这样一个地步——在全国范围内来看，即使是令经济生产维持原有规模都已经不可能了。这种程度的毁灭是封建体制下根本不可能发生的，封建领主本身就是生产资料的拥有者和生产的组织者及直接受益者，除非是疯子才会看到经济生产被破坏到这种程度仍不悬崖勒马。就算一定人口基数中总会出现一两个疯子，但是封建社会本身就不是复辟官僚国家那样集权的一元化社会，大大小小的领主都有自己的直辖领地管理，即使一两个领主就是如此疯癫，又怎么可能全国大部分领主都同时发疯呢？而我国现有的历史宣传竟然自相矛盾到了这样一种地步，一方面它把被官僚国家迫害到残缺不全的封建地主阶级视为只知享受的废物，另一方面又斥责这样的废物毁坏了整个国家。这种令人发笑的叙事，与一个强盗把一个人打成残疾，却反过来指责这个已经残疾的人犯下了不可饶恕的刑事案件，而这个刑事案件的罪魁祸首就是强盗这样荒诞不经的故事有一点半点的区别吗？而可悲的是，在中国大部分老百姓都相信这种叙事，朝廷和皇上永远是英明正确的，他们本意是好的，邪恶的永远是地主和官吏。

这种叙事当然不是只针对作为统治阶级的地主阶级，作为占人口绝大多数的被统治阶级而言，他们在叙事里干脆就是与畜牲一个地位的贱民了。例如在我上高中的时候标准历史教科书会解释为什么中国没有自发地产生工业革命或进入资本主义社会，其中一定少不了那一段著名的乾隆给马格尔尼的回信（天朝物产丰饶，无所不包……）。然后学生就会被告知，中国自己的生产力就已经过剩了，在鸦片贸易大兴之前连年顺差，因此既没有改良生产的动力也不愿意主动进行海外扩张。这个解释是如此的狡猾以至于它几乎总能欺骗到在高中时期因为学业和阅历短浅而无法深入思考的学生，因为他们还无法理解生产和消费是相互关联的两方，所谓生产过剩从另一个角度讲就是消费不足。事实上鸦片战争之后的历史完全证明了这一点，英国议会当年之所以以微弱优势赞同对中国发动战争，归根到底是他们自以为在迫使中国打开国门之后就会从中国这一“庞大的”市场中获得巨额利润。然而鸦片战争之后的事狠狠地打了英国人的脸，中国人是如此的穷困以至于完全不具备消费英国产品的能力，整个大清四亿人的市场竟然不及一个墨西哥。如此一来，这个问题就从“为什么中国的老百姓赤贫到这样一种惨绝人寰的地步”变成了“我们国家是多么伟大，压根不需要机器就能生产多少社会财富”，官僚体制不但洗脱了其滔天罪行，更逆天的是反倒为可怜无法思考的老百姓提供了民族主义的兴奋剂。我倒想多问一问，是谁让中国的老百姓日夜挣扎在死亡线上，以至于对消费的贡献几乎为零呢？

实际上，如果一个人住在中国住上一段时间就会非常清楚地认识到，无论是过去还是现在，中国的统治者本质上将其人民视为畜牲，从心里认为它们只要能活着就不需要有余财，是压根不配进行消费的。中国过去的三驾马车里面其实真正在跑的马也就是一个外贸出口，至于投资和消费在统治者看来算什么东西啊？直到最近几年随着中国制造的成本优势正在被亚非拉同样不缺劳动力的国家所抵消，人口形势的急转直下更加加剧了这一点。美国与中国开始公开地进行贸易战，而我们国家在技术创新上的能力是极为贫弱的，在各个产业特别是高附加值产业根本就没有什么竞争力。再加上中国和西方特别是美国之间的关系渐行渐远，而我国的所谓市场经济体制根本就是一个笑话（其实在中国几乎人人都知道这一点，只不过大家不说出来罢了），在进行产业转移的时候发达国家也更愿意选择成本更低，投资更有安全保障的其他发展中国家。对外出口这匹马终于还是无法像以前一样疾驰了，紧接着三年可笑的疫情防控更是给了气喘吁吁的老马当头一棒。这个时候中国的统治者才想起消费了（他们当然不会指望投资，因为中国是什么投资环境他们心里清楚），大大小小的官员们唯恐不能榨干老百姓身上的每一枚硬币，而老百姓身上早就没有钱了，多少人棺材本都拿去还房贷了。

后来一个偶然的事情让我意识到其实政府一直在有组织有目的地去引导和限制人们的思考。中国的年轻人对网络小说不会太陌生，就算你再不怎么看，只要一直接触互联网总会听过一两本比较出圈的作品。我本人也不怎么看网络小说，就是在没有什么事做的时候会偶尔刷上一刷。2023年末的时候，有一次我刷到了一本国内作者写的架空历史小说，大概是在地理大发现时期海外华人独立建国这样的剧情。当我看了几十个章节之后突然发现作者在某一章后面留下了一段声明，说自己原本设想的剧情是华人在海外建立一个资产阶级民主国家，但是平台的工作人员告诉他说，这种小说主角必须称孤道寡才能通过审核，所以他不得不把剧情改为在海外称帝，但是他还是说自己会坚持自己的想法，即使写称帝也一定

是君主立宪。这件事给我造成了极大的震动，我第一次如此真切地感受到我生活的土地就是一个庞大的囚笼，中国的统治者唯恐百姓不知道皇帝的威严，日夜担心有朝一日百姓见到官员居然可以不用下跪。